Title: Are College Rankings an Indicator of Quality Education?

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Abst: Educators need a way of determining how much additional knowledge has been gained by students in a given educational program in comparison with other programs. From the U.S. Teacher Education Study in Mathematics (TEDS), they now have such information. The TEDS yields empirical data on the educational experiences and content knowledge gains of a nationally representative sample of future teachers prepared at a wide variety of institutions. By combining data from the TEDS study with college selectivity measures--specifically the respected Barron's college rankings--it is now possible to estimate the degree to which selective schools provide a superior education, at least in one academic discipline. Other studies, such as that of Arum, Roksa, and Choe (2011), examined learning gains across disciplines using generic measures of cognitive ability such as critical thinking that may or may not be appropriate to specific majors. The virtue of the TEDS study is that it focuses on only one--those preparing to become teachers of primary and early secondary mathematics--which permits specific assessments of content acquisition. In this paper the authors focus on future lower secondary teachers. (Contains 3 tables, 5 figures, and 5 footnotes.)

Key-words: Academic Achievement, Educational Quality, Educational Experience, Cognitive Ability, Classification, Achievement Gains, Achievement Rating, Pedagogical Content Knowledge, Preservice Teacher Education, Preservice Teachers, Mathematics Teachers, Secondary School Mathematics, Outcome Measures, Robustness (Statistics), Educational Indicators, College Outcomes Assessment

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